

# It Only Takes *OneBite*: Attention Shocks in Local Markets<sup>\*</sup>

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## Abstract:

In an era of information abundance, scarce attention constrains consumer choice. Exploiting a unique quasi-experimental setting, I evaluate how viral attention from a *OneBite* pizza review affects consumption decisions. Using a staggered event study, I estimate that total customers at the reviewed pizzeria increase 6.2% in the first month following the review. However, the increase critically depends on the review score. While scores  $< 7.0$  and scores in the range  $[7.0, 8.0)$  do not generate an increase in customers, scores  $\geq 8.0$  increase customers by an average of 43% in each of the first three months following the review. The response is particularly large for non-local consumers, who have less prior knowledge of local alternatives. The surge in customer traffic generates positive spatial spillovers onto nearby drinking places, consistent with consumer-based agglomeration from the shared customer base. Despite the initial increase, viral attention fades as monthly customers return to their pretreatment level within four months. Using a bounded consideration model, I separate the demand response into an attention channel that increases awareness of the pizzeria and an information channel that updates a consumer's belief about its quality. Simulated maximum likelihood estimates show that although the score changes perceived quality, increased attention is the dominant mechanism to explain the increase in customers.

**Keywords:** Attention Economy, Limited Consideration, Social Media, Spatial Spillovers  
**JEL Codes:** D12, D8, M3, R10

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